

FIGHTING SPIRIT Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge (centre) with Sachin Pilot and Rajasthan Congress chief Govind Singh Dotasra (right) at a campaign rally in Chittorgarh

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was the Congress and its three INDIA allies—the Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP), CPI(M) and Rashtriya Loktantrik Party (RLP)—who won a seat each in Banswara-Dungarpur, Sikar and Nagaur respectively. In seats where INDIA candidates won, votes were clinched by caste equations and issues like anti-incumbency against sitting MPs, safeguarding the Constitution and reservation for SCs/ STs and anger against the Centre's Agnipath scheme. By contrast, a complacent BJP mostly depended on the appeal of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. As a result, the BJP's 14 LS seats are now equivalent to 106 assembly seats; INDIA's 11 signify wins in 89 assembly constituencies. "Congress's net votes in each of the assembly constituencies in 10 of the 11 LS seats INDIA won were more than the BJP's. Clearly, it cashed in whereas the BJP relying on Modi alone ignored it," says Barmer-based political analyst Amit Rakesh Sharma.

Though he campaigned extensively, Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma, a first-time MLA, cannot be blamed for the loss of 11 seats. That falls on the party high command and some state leaders. Yet, the BJP's hope that Sharma, who is from Bharatpur in eastern Rajasthan, would boost the party's chances in a region dominated by Gurjars and Meenas came to naught. The BJP lost Bharatpur to Sanjana Jatav of the Congress; adjoining Tonk-Sawai Madhopur, Dausa and Karauli-Dholpur too were lost.

The lukewarm LS results have strengthened the case of Vasundhara Raje, whose sidelining is considered to be a factor in BJP's decline

RETURN OF RAJE?

So does all this signify a comeback for Raje? Indeed, the LS results and the growing dissent against the first-time CM have strengthened her position. Even veteran Kirodi Lal Meena, the agriculture minister, has indicated his intention to quit, owning responsibility for defeat in those very eastern constituencies that were entrusted to him. If this transpires, Meena, who is upset with his portfolio and little say in government, will encourage more dissent, which will force the high command to act. It remains to be seen if the top brass will hand more power to Raje or accommodate her son Dushyant, who has won for the fifth time from Jhalawar-Baran. With the Sharma government considered the weakest in years, there are calls to bring in Raje as CM for half its term.

With their house in better order than when it went to the assembly polls after five years of feuding between former CM Ashok Gehlot and his one-time deputy Sachin Pilot, the Congress is happy with a weakened BJP. Gehlot, however, has his son Vaibhav's loss from Jalore to reckon with. Moreover, of the eight Congress candidates who have won, at least four are loyalists of his bête noir Pilot. Given that present Rajasthan Congress chief Govind Singh Dotasra has proven his worth, the high command is unlikely to replace him. Pilot now has time to build his credibility to present himself as the chief ministerial face for the 2029 assembly election. The LS polls have left both the BJP and Congress in Rajasthan with a lot to set right. ■